

Catering Performance at a UK Airport

A commercial data project. Company name withheld and dataset anonymised.

I was given eighteen months of monthly sales and transaction data for five catering outlets at a UK airport, together with monthly passenger numbers, and asked to turn it into something a commercial team could use day to day. This is how I approached it and what the data showed. I have kept the airport anonymous throughout.

The data

The file covered January 2024 to June 2026. Five outlets: two coffee bars and three restaurants, sitting in different parts of the terminal. For each outlet and month I had the number of transactions, total sales, the unit size in square metres, and where it sat in the terminal. Passenger counts came as a separate monthly table.

Two things needed fixing before any analysis. The outlet names and years were held in merged cells, so most rows were blank and no formula could read them. I flattened that into a plain table with a value on every row. The bigger issue was time: 2026 only ran to June, so comparing full years would make this year look like a collapse when really the data just stops halfway through.

How I built it

The whole workbook runs on formulas rather than values pasted out of a pivot, so anyone reviewing it can follow every number back to the source. Totals use SUMIFS against the cleaned table. The per-outlet view uses INDEX and MATCH to pull each outlet's type and location, and MAXIFS for its current size, since two of the units were expanded partway through the period. The dashboard links to this calculation tab, so nothing is typed in by hand and the whole thing updates if the source changes.

The one real judgement call was how to compare years. Because 2026 has no data past June, I compared the same six months, January to June, across all three years. That is the only fair read, and it has a useful side effect: it steps around a data problem I found in August 2024, which I come back to below.

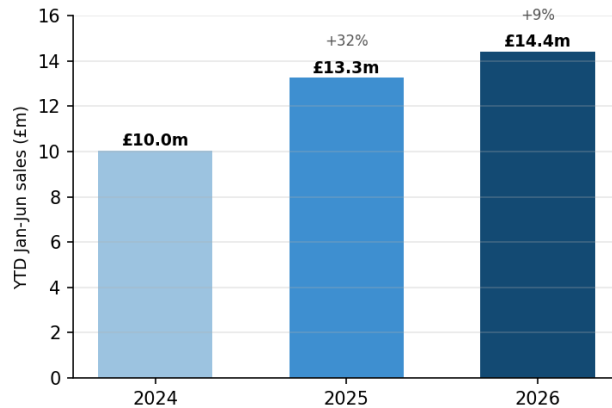
Output				
Full year sales				
Metric	2024	2025	2026	
Total Sales	£26,494,374	£29,272,430	£14,421,758	
Total Transactions	1,747,639	2,216,183	1,082,253	
ATV	£15.16	£13.21	£13.33	
(2026 is Jan-Jun only, so full-year 2026 is not comparable)				
YTD Jan-Jun (like-for-like)				
Metric	2024	2025	2026	
YTD Sales	£10,048,159	£13,255,458	£14,421,758	
YTD Transactions	823,543	1,015,380	1,082,253	
YTD ATV	£12.20	£13.05	£13.33	
YTD Passengers	7,302,574	7,772,578	8,193,486	
Spend per passenger	£1.38	£1.71	£1.76	
Monthly total sales				
Month	2024	2025	2026	

The calculation tab. Every cell is a formula; the values shown are what they resolve to.

What the data showed

Growth is real, but slowing

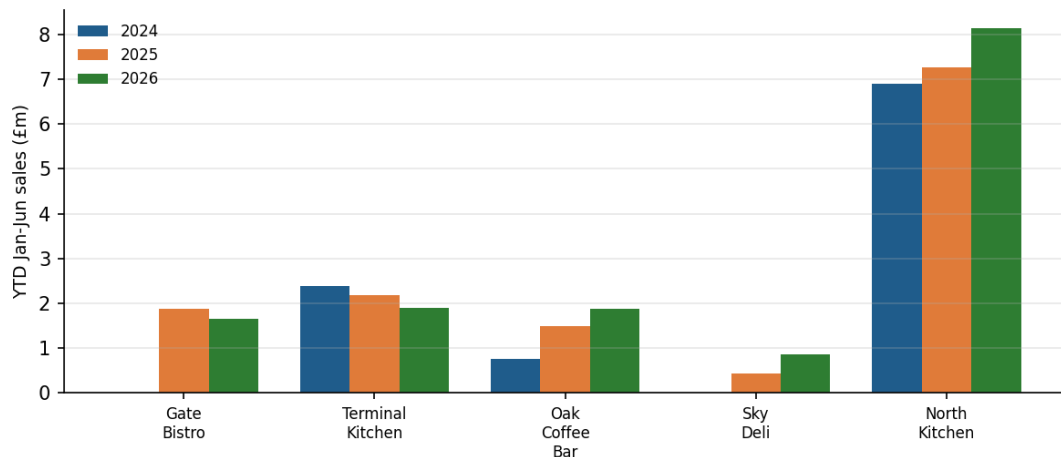
On a like-for-like basis, first-half catering sales went from £10.0m in 2024 to £13.3m in 2025 and £14.4m in 2026. The direction is good. The rate is not: growth fell from about 32 percent in the first year to about 9 percent in the second. I would want to understand why before assuming the line keeps climbing.



Like-for-like sales, January to June each year.

One outlet carries the estate

North Kitchen brings in roughly £8.2m of the £14.4m, so more than half of all catering revenue comes from a single restaurant. It is also the largest unit by floor space. That is a strength and a risk sitting in the same number: a strong quarter there flatters the whole estate, and a weak one would drag it down on its own.



First-half sales by outlet. North Kitchen (far right) dwarfs the rest.

One outlet is quietly shrinking

Terminal Kitchen is the only outlet going backwards, from £2.4m to £2.2m to £1.9m across the three half-years. Its transactions also dropped sharply in January and February 2026, down to a few thousand from a normal thirty thousand or so. That shape usually points to a closure or a refit, and it is the first thing I would ask the operator about.

Most of the growth is new outlets

Two outlets opened during the period: Gate Bistro in late 2024 and Sky Deli in mid 2025. A good part of the headline growth is simply them coming online, not existing outlets selling more. Strip the new units out and the underlying growth is softer than the top line suggests. Both matter, but they are different stories and a commercial team should see them apart.

A number that is almost certainly wrong

August 2024 for Terminal Kitchen reads £5.16m, at an average spend of about £134 per transaction against a normal figure near £13. That is roughly ten times too high and looks like a mis-keyed value in the source. I left it in place and flagged it rather than quietly deleting it, and I built the main comparison on January to June so that it does not lean on that month at all. You can actually see the spike in the monthly chart on the dashboard, which is a small argument for plotting raw data before trusting a total.

Spend per passenger

Because this is an airport, I also worked out catering spend per passenger, which is the number a commercial team tends to manage against. It rose from £1.38 to £1.71 to £1.76 across the three half-years. So passengers are spending a little more on food and drink each year, though the move from 2025 to 2026 is small and worth watching rather than celebrating.

The dashboard

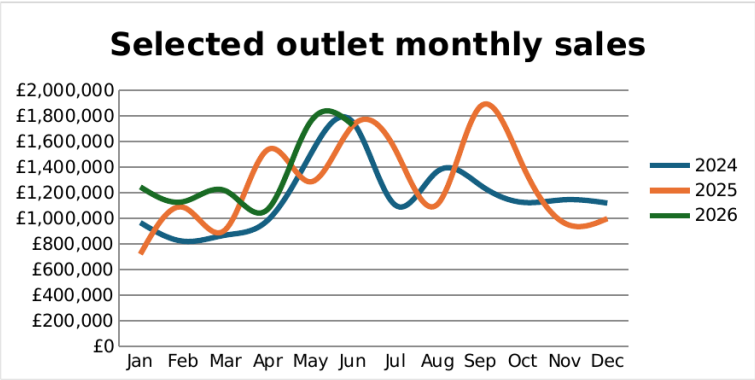
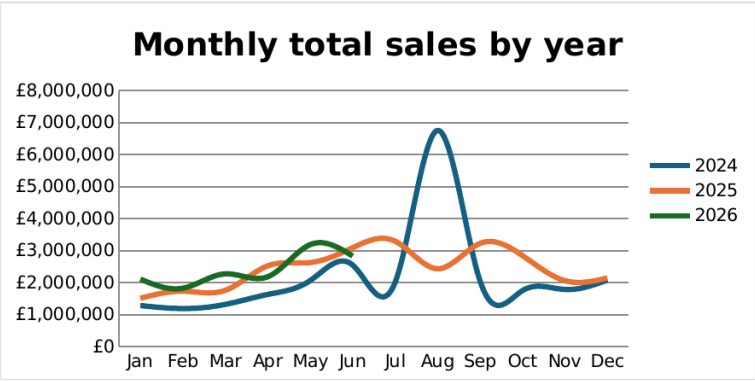
The dashboard sits on top of the calculations. It shows the headline numbers for the current year to date, a monthly sales trend with a separate line per year, and a per-outlet view driven by a dropdown so the team can switch between outlets without touching the data. The 2026 line stops at June on purpose, so a viewer is not misled into reading empty months as zero sales.

Catering Dashboard

Monthly sales, Jan 2024 - Jun 2026. Figures link to the Output tab.

Outlet: North Kitchen (pick from dropdown)

Headline (YTD Jan-Jun 2026)	
YTD Sales	£14,421,758
YoY vs 2025	8.8%
Transactions	1,082,253
ATV	£13.33
Spend per passenger	£1.76



The interactive dashboard. The dropdown drives the lower chart.

Limitations and what I would do next

A few honest caveats. The August 2024 figure needs confirming with whoever owns the data before anyone acts on the 2024 totals. I would want to know what happened at Terminal Kitchen in early 2026 before reading too much into its decline. And with only eighteen months I can see one year-on-year step, not a trend I would stake much on.

Given a longer history I would look properly at seasonality, and at how each outlet's sales move with passenger numbers month to month, since that link is really what an airport can act on when it sets rents and plans the retail mix. The Excel workbook with the live formulas is available on request.

Dataset anonymised. Airport name withheld. Built in Excel.